

STILL YOU

An interactive memory-walk in four hallways.

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Play: agentfriedrice.github.io/Still-You/

Storyboard & flowchart: </docs/storyboard.html>

Concept

Still You is a 2D pixel-art web experience where the player walks through four memory-like hallways — one for each year of college — encountering small objects from the past and making quiet choices about what to keep, what to set down, and what to hand to someone else. The choices shape a reflective ending about growth, regret, care, and identity. The title is the question the project answers: across four years of becoming, what stays?

The Arc

Six beats, played in order:

- **Title screen.** One softly-glowing cream window, drifting dust, “*a memory in four hallways.*” The window is in the Year 4 palette because the start and the end should rhyme.
- **Year 1 — Arrival.** Cool blue. What you brought with you. Packed box, dorm key, syllabus, first call.
- **Year 2 — Settling.** Dim green. What you started keeping. Major form, unread message, notebook, 3am cup.
- **Year 3 — Reckoning.** Amber. What you weighed yourself against. Rejection, lanyard, half-built portfolio, empty week.
- **Year 4 — Becoming.** Warm cream. What you carry out. Thesis, graduation cap, goodbye note, empty room. The final doorway shows a two-stage closing: a per-year recap, then a cumulative line drawn from every choice across every year.
- **Epilogue (optional).** If the player picks “*stay a little longer*” at the final doorway, a chair appears, the sun fills the room, and they can walk back through every hallway — now illuminated — to meet their first-year self at the original spawn point. One choice. *hug*. Whisper: “*you were always going to make it.*”

Visual Design

A 4:3 boxed viewport with CRT scanlines and a vignette frame, to invoke the feeling of an old game cartridge that remembers you. Composite pixel-style sprites built entirely from primitive rectangles — no external assets. Each year has its own palette and a matching outfit re-tint on the player; hair, skin, and eyes stay constant (the “you” that persists), while torso, collar, and legs shift to sit inside the new colorwave. The back wall of every hallway carries framed windows with cross mullions and sills, and ambient lamp pools overhead. Drifting dust particles, tinted to each year, give the air weight.

Mechanics

Three keys: **WASD** to move, **E** to interact or advance, **Q** to back out. Each memory presents three choice flavors — *keep*, *leave*, or *pass on* — and the dominant tendency per year selects the doorway reflection. The dominant tendency across *all* choices selects the cumulative closing line. Doorways are dismissible: players can step back, revise, and re-trigger. There is no failure state; the only consequence of skipping a memory is the doorway hint stays at n/5 and the year refuses to resolve.

Implementation

Built in JavaScript on Phaser 3, hosted as a static site on GitHub Pages. Twelve modular files, each owning one concern: `state.js` for shared globals, `hallways.js` for the per-year data (palettes, memories, reflections, outfits), `visuals.js` for the procedural atmosphere builder, `dialogue.js` for the three-state dialogue machine, `ending.js` for the doorway lifecycle, `chair.js` for the “stay a while” sit-and-illuminate sequence, and `epilogue.js` for the post-chair walk-back and the hug. Two Phaser scenes (`TitleScene` → `GameScene`) handle the open and the close. Every memory is data, not code — adding a new one is a one-place edit.

Final Demo Setup

Runs in any modern browser (Phaser 3 loaded from CDN). Keyboard-only input. A fullscreen button on the title; the 4:3 viewport scales cleanly to a projector or large monitor. No audio — silence is part of the design. Refreshing the page resets all choices, intentionally; a clean playthrough takes about 12–18 minutes, or 20–25 if the player takes the epilogue path.

Reflection

The hardest design choices were the quiet ones. Whether memories should re-open in the epilogue (they don’t — the past is past). Whether the hug needed a swelling glow (it didn’t — just a lean held still for four seconds). Whether the final whisper should be a paragraph (it shouldn’t — one line). The biggest lesson of the project was that restraint, in writing and in motion, did more work than ornament ever would. The full per-year breakdown, palette swatches, hallway mockups, and system flowchart are in the linked storyboard.